

Chapter 148_1 - Three Bows

Moonlight spilled across that person's shoulder, the green robes tinted with faint moon-white. The woman stood quietly at the bottom of the steps for a long time before finally turning and walking out of the silent Jingshan Palace under the night sky.

Someone approached on the stone steps outside Jingshan Palace. Red robes were quite striking under the swaying tree shadows, with several delicate, jingling bracelets around her fair wrists, lively and charming.

"Little bird?" Jiuying saw her and breathed a sigh of relief, quickly walking a few steps to draw level with her. "Where's Ning Fuyi?"

"I just rushed back from outside and saw the remaining fires burning from afar, only then learning that Penglai had actually targeted Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate."

Qiu Yi couldn't help but step back following her movements, but quickly stopped and shifted her gaze toward the night sky outside: "She's asleep."

"Then I'll go see her," Jiuying moved around her to enter Jingshan Palace, but was blocked by Qiu Yi's quick intervention. The two nearly collided.

Qiu Yi's face visibly reddened to her ears. She extended her hands slightly to block the path, opening her mouth: "Master is also inside. It's better if you don't go."

"Besides, she's fine, just tired."

Jiuying's gaze swept over her, then she smiled broadly and put her hands on her hips, as if she understood everything: "That's right, the two of them are having their private time together. I won't go disturb them. I'll go check on Ping'an."

After speaking, she twisted her waist and turned around, but her sleeve was suddenly caught by a force.

It was Qiu Yi reaching out to grab her, though her fingertips quickly released as if the red fabric burned her hands.

Jiuying looked at her own sleeve, then at her, suddenly remembering something and turning around seriously: "A few days ago Ning Fuyi was asking me about you. You've been absent for so long - where exactly did you go?"

Qiu Yi was stunned for a moment and blurted out: "She was worried about me?"

"Of course," Jiuying laughed lightly. "Since you're the Divine Venerable's disciple, how could she not care? Not just her - even I was thinking that if you didn't show up soon, I'd have to follow your scent to find you."

"These days are chaotic, with demons and evil spirits appearing frequently outside. You should go wandering around less by yourself," Jiuying instructed.

"Alright," Qiu Yi met Jiuying's eyes directly without looking away for the first time, nodding in agreement.

Jiuying seemed to sense something was off but couldn't pinpoint what, so she looked away first, coughed once, and turned in place: "I'm going to see Ping'an."

"Wait," Qiu Yi suddenly mustered courage to speak, gripping her skirt hem as she stepped forward quickly, saying in a low voice: "I brought back some wine from outside, but I don't have any friends at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, so..."

"Could you accompany me for a few drinks?" She looked up.

Jiuying seemed quite surprised, her willow brows rising, but she still agreed.

The unextinguished fires in the distance flickered bright and dark, looking like real ghost fires among the dark tree shadows. From time to time, disciples ran back and forth reinforcing the barrier, passing by the two of them.

Qiu Yi led Jiuying to an open area behind Zhuguan Pavilion. This place was surrounded by green bamboo, quiet and uninhabited, with bamboo leaves carpeting the ground like a mat that rustled when stepped on.

The stone table and stone benches were clean, clearly showing someone often came here to sit idly.

"Zhuguan Pavilion has such a place," Jiuying sat down on a stone bench. The night was cool as water, with a bright moon overhead whose light was partially hidden by bamboo leaves.

"Yes, I discovered it by chance while wandering," Qiu Yi sat across from Jiuying, taking out several wine jugs, cups, and two roasted chickens wrapped in oiled paper and still giving off heat from her waist pouch.

Seeing this, Jiuying curved her eyebrows, her fingertips painted with rouge quickly unwrapping the oiled paper, saying with satisfaction: "Thank you."

"You don't seem worried?" Qiu Yi filled her cup with wine, no longer avoiding her but looking up with moonlight reflected in her eyes.

"Worried about what? This world?" Jiuying tore off a piece of meat and put it in her mouth, her lips deep red as she smiled: "I've lived longer than your master. I've long accepted that life and death are matters of fate. Living is certainly important, but sometimes, it's not that important."

Qiu Yi's eyes showed confusion.

"It's not that I want to die," Jiuying shook her head. "It's just that I'm no longer so obsessed with my own life and death. But thinking carefully, if the world really were destroyed, I'd never again be able to eat such delicious roasted chicken."

She held the crispy outside, tender inside roasted chicken and sighed: "Thinking this way, there's still some reluctance."

"When immortals speak of 'the world,' these two words sound light and meaningless, but if you think carefully about what they truly encompass, they suddenly feel heavy," Jiuying shrugged.

"Grass and trees, rivers, high mountains, beasts, family, lovers, friends."

"And this wine and these delicacies - if you count them all, they're all part of the world," Jiuying sighed.

Qiu Yi's eyes flickered as she sipped some clear wine.

Then she suddenly spoke: "Do you know? You're my first real friend. Although... you deceived me."

Jiuying raised her eyebrows in surprise.

"From when I picked up your green feather and began talking with you daily through it, I had my first person I could confide my thoughts to. I used to live with Master on the desolate Purple Cloud Peak, and Master isn't someone you can have heart-to-heart talks with, so even though I had a heart full of words, I could only speak them to random rocks."

"I often guessed your identity, imagining you to be exactly like this," Qiu Yi seemed drunk but showed no signs of intoxication, giggling: "Composed and elegant, responding to every sentence I wrote."

"And those responses made me feel like I was bathed in spring breeze, as if we'd known each other for years, never rejecting my naive concerns."

Jiuying's roasted chicken suddenly lost its flavor. She was silent for a moment, then put it down.

"I know I'm childish, impulsive, and not good with words, but you never disdained me. Instead, you could always comfort me just right," Qiu Yi supported her chin with her hand, her gaze nostalgic.

"To you it might have just been manipulation, but to me, that was the happiest period of my life."

Jiuying, usually carefree, felt somewhat stifled hearing this and lowered her hand, saying "sorry."

"No need to apologize," Qiu Yi shook her head. "I'm not asking you for an explanation. It's just that the moonlight is too beautiful, inspiring emotion."

The two drank silently for several cups. Jiuying pursed her red lips and broke the silence: "So where exactly did you go these days, if you don't mind saying..."

"I went back to Cangyun Kingdom," Qiu Yi answered honestly without concealment. "I wandered among those ruins where no one sets foot anymore, imagining how busy and prosperous it once was."

"You mentioned it was your hometown," Jiuying said.

"Yes, my hometown that I have no memories of," Qiu Yi looked toward the moon. The tree shadows had changed direction now, with the moon completely risen overhead.

"Other places have gained new inhabitants and built prosperous cities, but only that sacred ground of the capital remains ruins. The palace walls still stand, covered in dust and weeds, with spiders weaving webs there."

Qiu Yi spoke lightly, then suddenly raised her cup toward the moon, as if toasting those departed souls, then drank the wine in one gulp.

"Why aren't you drinking?" Qiu Yi turned back to lean on the table, asking softly, her tone carrying a hint of the petulance she hadn't shown in a long time.

Jiuying picked up her wine cup and obediently drank the wine inside. Only then did Qiu Yi smile with satisfaction.

"Alright, there might be fierce battles tomorrow. Drink less and rest early," Jiuying said in a deep voice, reaching out to help Qiu Yi up, but the other party seemed already drunk and remained limp no matter how she tried to help.

"Jiuying, I know you all don't like me," Qiu Yi pulled her hand away, swaying as she stood up. "You, Ning Fuyi, and everyone else - none of you like me."

"Only Master likes me, only Master treats me well, so I'd risk my life to treat Master well," Qiu Yi wiped the corner of her eyes with the back of her hand.

"Qiu Yi!" Jiuying wanted to simply use immortal power to make her sleep, but her hand was pushed away.

"You always bully me too. You deceived me, used me, threw away my feather," Qiu Yi broke free from Jiuying, swaying as she stood steady. "I hate bugs, and I especially don't like eating locusts!"

Jiuying could only stand in place, her slender phoenix eyes lowered, helplessly watching her drunken behavior.

"Do you hate me?" Qiu Yi stood under the falling bamboo leaves, saying with reddened eyes.

Jiuying shook her head, frowning: "Qiu Yi, stop making a scene."

She was about to step forward to comfort her when she suddenly felt the moonlight dim slightly. Alarmed, she quickly circulated her power to steady herself, but she had discovered it too late - it was already useless.

Then her legs went weak and she fell forward on her knees. The woman who had seemed drunk just moments ago had somehow flashed to her front and was slowly helping her to the ground.

The bamboo leaves beneath were soft. Jiuying weakly turned over to lie flat, the moonlight making her skin appear even more fair and translucent.

Footnotes:

1. This chapter title "三拜" (Three Bows) refers to a traditional Chinese ceremony of three prostrations, often performed to show deep respect, gratitude, or farewell. The specific context becomes clear at the end of this chapter section.